INC-2041 Incident Report - Card authorization delays

Date: 2026-03-05
Severity: SEV-1
Status: Resolved
Duration: 3 h 40 min (09:40 to 13:20 UTC)

Summary

On 2026-03-05 card authorizations were delayed and many timed out. Between 09:40 and 13:20 UTC about 18% of card authorization requests failed, and most of the others completed slowly. The incident lasted 3 h 40 min.

Impact

About 18% of card authorization requests failed with a gateway timeout during the incident window. Merchants saw declined or slow card payments at checkout. No data was lost.

Timeline (UTC)

- 09:00 CHG-0314 deployed: fraud-scorer model v4 serves all traffic.
- 09:40 Alerts for payments-gateway timeouts; incident opened.
- 10:05 fraud-scorer p99 latency observed at about 900 ms, up from about 80 ms before the rollout.
- 10:30 ledger-service reports its database connection pool at 50 of 50 connections in use.
- 11:15 Incident raised to SEV-1.
- 13:05 fraud-scorer rolled back to model v3.
- 13:20 Authorization success rate back to normal; incident resolved.

Root cause

The incident was caused by two changes acting together. CHG-0314 rolled out fraud model v4, which made fraud-scorer much slower: the observed p99 latency was about 900 ms. payments-gateway calls fraud-scorer synchronously and keeps its ledger-service session, and with it a ledger DB connection, open until the authorization completes. Slow fraud scoring therefore kept ledger DB connections checked out for much longer than usual.

Two days earlier CHG-0311 had reduced the ledger DB connection pool from 200 to 50 connections. With the smaller pool and the longer hold time the pool was exhausted, new authorizations waited for a connection, and payments-gateway hit its timeout.

Affected services

- payments-gateway
- fraud-scorer
- ledger-service

Resolution

fraud-scorer was rolled back to model v3 at 13:05 UTC. Latency dropped, connections were released and the authorization success rate recovered by 13:20 UTC.

Action items

- Restore the ledger DB connection pool to 200 connections (raised as CHG-0331).
- Add alerting on ledger DB pool saturation.
- Load test new fraud models with production-like traffic before rollout.